

A postage stamp showing the revolutionary V. D. Savarkar, who coined the word *Hindutva*, showing in the background the cellular prison on the Andaman Islands penal colony where he spent many of his twenty-seven years in jail and exile in the 1920s and 1930s.

The other side of Periyar was his work as a social reformer, which led to the creation in 1925 of his Self-Respect Movement, formalised in 1952 with such laudable aims as

> to allow people to live a life of freedom from slavery to anything against reason and self-respect; to do away with needless customs, meaningless ceremonies, and blind superstitious beliefs in society; to put an end to the present social system in which caste, religion, community and traditional occupations based on the accident of birth, have chained the mass of the people and created ‘superior’ and ‘inferior’ classes … and to give people equal rights; to completely eradicate untouchability and to establish a united society based on brother/sisterhood; to give equal rights to women; to